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WALKING THE TALK Priyanka Gandhi at the Shakti Samvaad event in Firozabad in December 2021

FROM GROUND ZERO TO HALF THE SKY...

THE CONGRESS IS NOWHERE IN THE CONTEST IN UP. BUT AT A TIME WHEN CASTE IS THE LEITMOTIF, IT MAKES A VIRTUE OUT OF ADVERSITY: FEMINISING POLITICS WITH 40 PER CENT SEATS TO WOMEN

By Prashant Srivastava

IT'S NEVER A GOOD IDEA TO prejudge an electoral contest. But to the naked eye, there appear only two players in the game: the ruling BJP, and a newly energised Samajwadi Party. Most smaller pieces on the chessboard cohere around these two—a bipolarity that apparently leaves no great room even for Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party. Where does that leave the Congress, out of the reckoning in Uttar Pradesh for over three decades? Well, Priyanka Gandhi, helming the Grand Old Party's desperate search for relevance, has chosen to try and extract virtue out of adversity by sowing a new crop in this tired, old soil.

At a time when everyone is talking caste, she's seeking to get the debate to pivot on another axis altogether: gender. A full 40 per cent of the party's candidates in UP will be women. Quite a bold figure—by comparison, even the demand for one-third seats made in